

VOLUNTEERISM IN CANADIAN URBAN FORESTRY

Results from the 2025 Canadian Urban Forest Census

by Alexander Martin and Tenley Conway

Volunteers are an active component of Canadian urban forestry, contributing to tree planting, watering, public outreach, and other stewardship activities. These opportunities allow members of the public, arborists, and organized groups to participate in urban forestry and environmental stewardship. Initiatives may range from one-off events to formal partnerships between municipalities and organizations that mobilize volunteers, with many larger municipalities also employing staff to coordinate volunteer programs.

In the United States, the *2014 Urban & Community Forestry Census* (Hauer & Peterson, 2016) estimated that 345,466 volunteers contribute 1,484,204 hours – equivalent to 714 full-time equivalent positions – to U.S. urban forestry activities. US municipalities most commonly engaged volunteers in tree planting (85%), followed by watering (40%) and educational programs (39%). Canada has previously lacked comparable data, despite the value of highlighting urban forestry as an area of civic engagement and helping municipalities benchmark their programs.

In 2025, we distributed the Canadian Urban Forest Census to Canada's 343 urban, non-Indigenous municipalities, receiving responses from 40% of the 343 municipalities. The 105-question survey covered arboriculture operations, urban forest management practices, budgets, staffing, tree inventories, and volunteerism. In this

article, we discuss the role of volunteers in Canadian urban forestry. In this article, we examine the role of volunteers in Canadian urban forestry, including a first-of-its-kind national estimate of volunteerism, followed by volunteer partnerships, activities, and training. This article provides an accessible version of the results published in *Urban Forestry & Urban Greening* (Martin et al., 2026).

Volunteers in Canadian Urban Forestry

Just over half of participating municipalities ($n = 72$, 52.6%) reported engaging volunteers in tree planting, tree care, or other urban forestry activities on public property. Volunteer engagement was more common in municipalities with larger urban forestry budgets and more staff, suggesting that volunteer programs tend to accompany, rather than replace, greater institutional capacity. Municipalities with larger populations and longer frost-free seasons were also more likely to engage volunteers. Canopy cover and whether respondents considered their budgets inadequate were not associated with volunteer involvement.

Among municipalities that engaged volunteers, the median program involved 40 volunteers contributing 150 hours annually. Higher budgets and staffing levels were associated with more volunteers and volunteer hours. Larger municipalities also engaged more volunteers and recorded more

hours, while higher-density municipalities recorded more volunteer hours.

To understand the national scale of this contribution, we used survey results to estimate volunteer activity across all 343 urban municipalities in Canada. We estimate that 165 municipalities engage urban forestry volunteers, totalling approximately 105,400 volunteers contributing 379,100 hours each year.

On a per-capita basis, Canadian municipalities averaged about 529 volunteers per 100,000 residents while the United States averaged 322 volunteers per 100,000 residents. These are comparable results that are statistically similar. However, compared with the US, Canadian municipalities appear to engage volunteers broadly but somewhat less intensively. Canadian volunteers contributed an average of 6.1 hours per person annually, compared with 9.82 hours among responding U.S. municipalities. Neither urban forestry budgets nor staffing were significantly associated with per-capita participation or individual contributions.

Lower volunteer hours in Canada may be consistent with broader declines in volunteerism reported in recent years. If municipalities are not relying on volunteers to deliver core urban forestry services, declining participation may have limited operational consequences. It could nevertheless reduce opportunities for the civic, social, and environmental benefits associated with community stewardship.

Volunteer Organizations Supporting Urban Forestry

Among municipalities that work with volunteers, individual residents were the most commonly engaged participants, reported by 57.1% of municipalities (n = 40). Municipalities also frequently partnered with local environmental groups (52.9%), schools and youth organizations such as Scouts (48.6%), non-profit or non-governmental organizations (37.1%), and private corporations (34.3%) (Figure 1). All other organization types were reported by fewer than one-third of municipalities. Municipalities with larger urban forestry budgets, more staff, and larger populations tended to work with a wider range of volunteer organizations.

The prominence of individual volunteers is similar to findings from the United States and may reflect a broader shift toward episodic, project-based volunteering rather than long-term involvement through formal organizations. The mix of partner organizations differed between the two countries, however. In Canada, local environmental groups and private corporations were among the most common partners, while park and tree boards and neighbourhood associations were more prominent in the United States. This may partly reflect differences in urban forestry governance, as community park and tree boards are more common in the United States.

Activities Supported by Volunteers

Volunteer activities were concentrated in lower-risk stewardship work, particularly tree planting. Naturalization planting – that is, planting in ravines, riparian areas, or forested areas – was by far the most common activity, reported by 82.9% of municipalities that engaged volunteers (n = 58) (Figure 2). Park tree planting followed at 70.0%, while street tree planting (21.4%) and community education and engagement (20.0%) were much less common. All other activities were reported by fewer than one-fifth of municipalities.

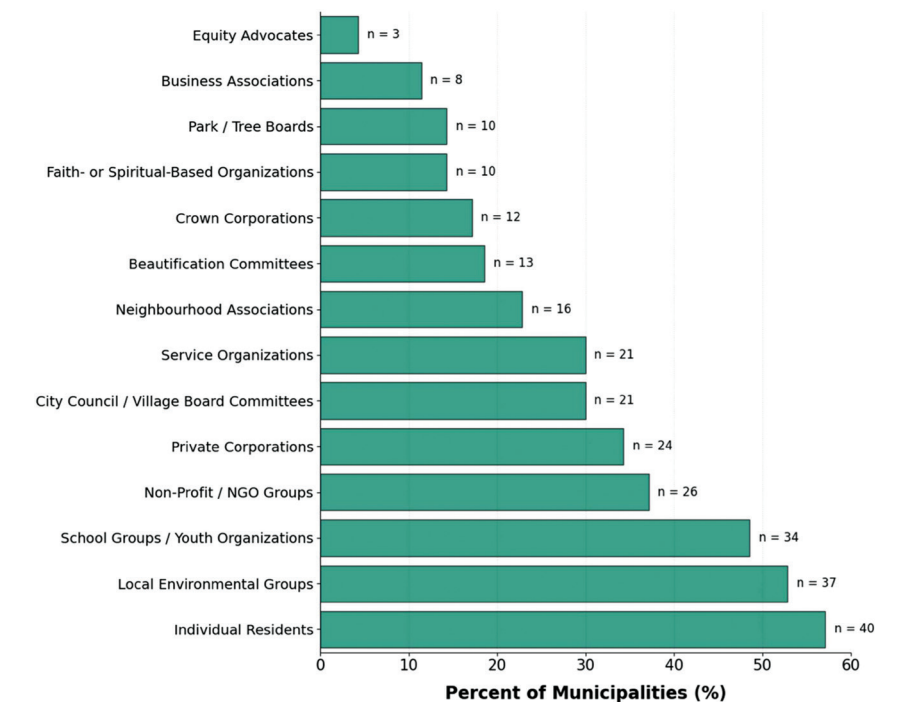


Figure 1: Pathways for volunteer engagement in Canadian urban forestry. Reproduced from Martin, Conway, and Fleming (2026).

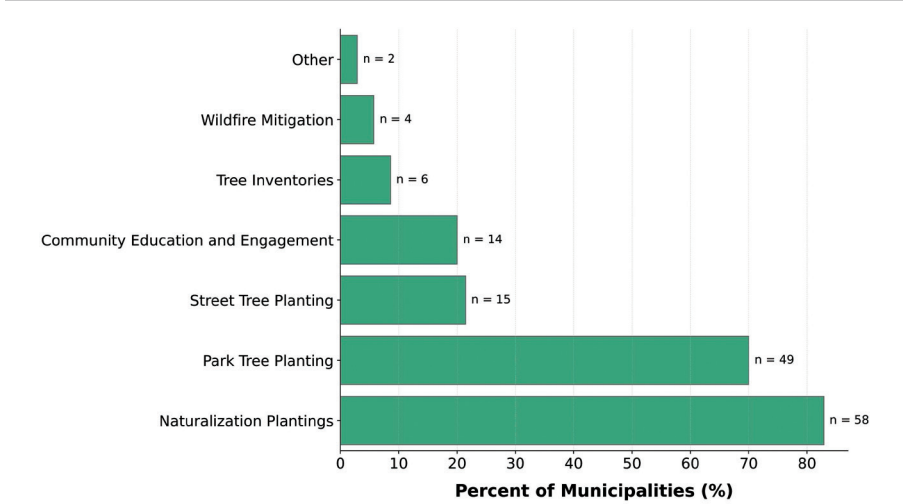


Figure 2: Urban forestry activities performed by volunteers working with municipalities. Reproduced from Martin, Conway, and Fleming (2026).

This emphasis on planting in parks and naturalized areas likely reflects both the accessibility and relatively low risk of these activities. Street planting and maintenance work were much less commonly supported by volunteers, although some municipalities offer training for residents interested in taking on more specialized tasks. Keeping higher-risk work in the hands of trained professionals helps protect

volunteers and reinforces an important distinction: volunteer programs can complement municipal urban forestry services, but they are not a substitute for professional staff.

The breadth of volunteer activity was not associated with urban forestry budgets or staffing levels. Instead, municipalities with higher population densities and greater canopy cover

supported a wider range of volunteer activities. In municipalities with more extensive urban forests, this may reflect a greater variety of stewardship opportunities, particularly in parks and naturalized areas that are well suited to volunteer participation.

Training Provided to Volunteers

Training was common among municipalities that worked with volunteers: 88.9% (n = 64) provided some form of training. Tree planting training was by far the most common, offered by 83.3% of municipalities, followed by safety training (47.2%) and tree identification (25.0%) (Figure 3). All other forms of training were offered by fewer than one-fifth of municipalities, and just eight municipalities reported providing no volunteer training. Municipalities typically offered two types of training, while those with larger urban forestry budgets and more staff tended to provide a wider range of training opportunities.

Canadian municipalities reported training volunteers more frequently than municipalities in the United States, where 79% provided training. The strong emphasis on tree planting mirrors the activities volunteers most often perform. Safety training, however, was offered by fewer than half of municipalities, which may partly reflect the concentration of volunteer work in lower-risk activities.

Providing training requires staff time and financial resources, reinforcing the broader pattern that volunteer programs depend on municipal capacity rather than simply compensating for a lack of it. Training may also strengthen volunteer programs in other ways, as building skills and knowledge has been identified as a sought-after benefit by urban forestry volunteers. This suggests that well-developed training programs may support both participation and retention.

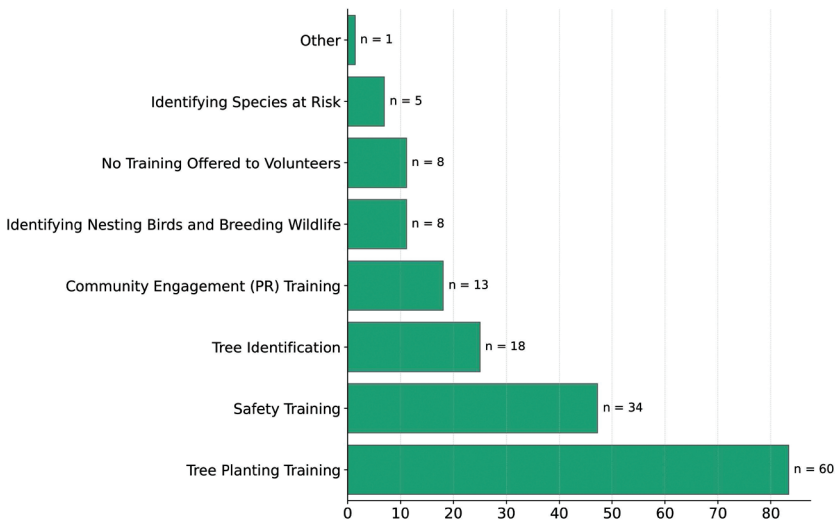


Figure 3: Types of volunteer training provided by municipalities working with urban forestry volunteers. Reproduced from Martin, Conway, and Fleming (2026).

Conclusions

The 2025 Canadian Urban Forest Census provides the first national picture of volunteer engagement in Canadian municipal urban forestry. Nationally, we estimate that 48.1% of Canadian urban municipalities engage volunteers, representing approximately 105,400 volunteers contributing 379,100 hours each year.

Municipalities with larger budgets and more staff engaged more volunteers, recorded more volunteer hours, worked with a wider range of partner organizations, and provided more types of training. By contrast, perceived budget inadequacy was not associated with greater volunteer involvement. Together, these findings suggest that volunteer programs depend on the staff time, resources, and organizational capacity needed to support them rather than compensating for inadequate staffing or funding.

This challenges interpretations of volunteerism as primarily a response to austerity. Instead, volunteerism in Canadian urban forestry aligns with United States findings that volunteers complement professional staff and public investment while adding value to urban forestry programs. That value may include increasing

public awareness of urban trees and strengthening community stewardship. Strong municipal programs create the capacity to involve volunteers, while volunteers broaden opportunities for community participation and connection to the urban forest.

References:

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